

Younger people are working harder than before, which is in keeping with other data, from MindShare Insights, based on 90 lakh 12-25-year-olds from the top 35 cities, which suggests that the earning age has declined to 19 years and that 54 per cent of the youngsters are earning while still studying. According to 2006-07 government estimates, 80 million youngsters have part-time jobs (entailing between eight and 29 hours of work every week). This may be why they have little time for the prolonged pleasures of life: 69 per cent had not read any novel in the past three months.

Even as they seem to have taken multiple choices for granted, young people show every sign of buckling down to eventual adulthood. The youth—and not just those who are

Work matters

One-third of the respondents work for over nine hours a day

The average number of hours spent at work is significantly higher in Bangalore, Kochi, Pune (where **14%** work for over nine hours a day), Ludhiana and Jaipur. This is also true for men and lower socio-economic sections and those who do not stay with their families.

Would you prefer to marry a working woman?

Yes **54**
No **39**
Can't say **7**

Would you ask your wife to give up her job after you have a child?

Yes **12**
No **19**
Let her decide **33**

*All figures in per cent;
Rest: Don't know/Can't say
Figures don't add up to 100*

HEMANT CHAWLA; Models: SAURABH KHANNA, NASREEN REHMAN (Elite Model Management); Accessories courtesy: DA MILANO

married—save 19 per cent of their income. Small town youth, though, save less than big city youth, perhaps because they believe consumption=success. Clearly, small towns are impatient to catch up with an urban mentality. Connectivity matters to young people—mobile and Internet bills are an important spend for the youth, constituting about 10 per cent of total income, even though Internet access is shockingly limited in a country that calls itself an IT superpower. While 16-24-year-olds are more Internet savvy (34 per cent log on at least once a week, as against 20 per cent for older youth), almost 60 per cent of the respondents have never accessed the World Wide Web. Prime time television is their prime source of entertainment—66 per cent of them normally watch tv between 8 and 11 p.m.

While they talk freely about their ambitions and aspirations, they are not as open about their habits. Over 70 per cent of the men say they have never smoked and 77 per cent say they don't drink—for women, the percentages are 95 and 93, respectively. What's more, only 10 per cent say they have had sex before marriage, which pales in comparison with our earlier surveys. It may have something to do with the methodology. This survey was done through street corner sampling. In our 2006 sex survey, which followed the secret ballot method, 30 per cent in the age group of 21-30 admitted to having had pre-marital sex.